

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Joshua

Joshua

The story of Israel's soldiers walking around Jericho until its walls fell is one of the most famous stories in the Bible. Joshua had served as Moses's helper. So when God made Joshua the leader of Israel, Joshua was ready. He led the Israelites across the Jordan River. Then he led them in two military campaigns, which helped them settle in the hill country of Canaan. After they began to live there, Joshua divided the land among the 12 tribes of Israel. The book of Joshua teaches important truths about God. God judges sin, and he faithfully keeps his promises.

Setting

When Israel was in Egypt, the Egyptians made them slaves. Egypt was powerful, rich, and well protected. But God acted to rescue Israel, and Egypt suffered great loss. Then the Israelites spent 40 years in the wilderness. This happened because they refused to trust that God could help them in Canaan, just as he had already helped them leave Egypt. That unbelieving generation died, and a new generation grew up. This new generation believed God's promises and was ready to enter the land of Canaan.

Ancient Canaan had four narrow regions that ran from north to south.

1. East of the Jordan River was the plateau of Transjordan. Transjordan means
2. West of Transjordan, the land drops steeply into the Jordan River valley. The shore of the Dead Sea is the deepest dry point in this valley. It is also the lowest dry land on earth.
3. The central hill country runs from the mountains and hills of Galilee in the north to the Negev in the south.
4. The coastal plain lies along the Mediterranean Sea. Near its northern end, the ridge of Mount Carmel reaches out into the sea.

In the story of Joshua, Israel began at Shittim in Transjordan. Then the Israelites crossed the Jordan River, conquered Jericho and the central hill country, and settled in the areas they had taken.

Much of Canaan was organized into small city-states. Each city-state had its own king. These city-states often joined together in groups, but these groups changed often. The southern and northern groups that fought against Israel were the closest these city-states came to being fully united. Even so, these

groups were not strong enough to save the Canaanites.

Summary

The first half of Joshua,, chapters 1-12, is one of the most dramatic stories in the Bible. As Joshua prepared Israel to cross the Jordan River, he sent two young men to spy on Jericho. Israel would have to conquer this town in order to enter the hill country. A woman named Rahab helped the two young spies. They promised to spare Rahab and her family because she helped them (chapter 2). The Israelites crossed the Jordan River after God stopped its flow by a miracle (chapter 3). Then God gave Israel the city of Jericho by causing its walls to fall (chapter 6).

After Israel took Jericho, the Israelites could enter the hill country to the west. But a man named Achan disobeyed God's instructions. This displeased the Lord, and Israel suffered a defeat. Later, Achan's sin was discovered and judged (chapter 7).

Then God gave Joshua a great victory over a southern group of Canaanite city-states. These city-states had quickly joined together to fight Israel. God even answered Joshua's request for the sun and moon to stand still until the battle was over (chapter 10).

Joshua then moved north and achieved a similar victory over a northern group of city-states (chapter 11). The entire hill country was open for Israel to settle in. This land reached from the Negev in the south to Upper Galilee in the north.

The second half of Joshua, chapters 13-24, tells how Israel's land was divided among the tribes. It gives many details about the land given to Judah, Benjamin, and Joseph's descendants (chapters 15-19). These tribes became the central tribes of Israel.

This section begins with Caleb's inheritance and ends with Joshua's inheritance (chapters 15 and 19). Then six cities of refuge were chosen. These were cities where a person could seek safety after accidentally killing someone (chapter 20). Towns were also given to the Levites inside each tribal area (chapter 21). This completed the process of dividing the land among the tribes.

The two and a half tribes who received land east of the Jordan River were then allowed to return home. But first, they had to correct a misunderstanding with the western tribes about a memorial they had built (chapter 22).

The book ends with Joshua's farewell speech (chapter 23). Then Joshua gathered the people to renew their

covenant with God. The book closes with three important burials (chapter 24).

Author and Date

The book of Joshua does not say that Joshua wrote it. The repeated phrase to this day shows that parts of the book were written after the events happened. This suggests that the book was written after Joshua's death.

However, some parts of the story use the word *we*. This may show that some of the book comes from personal memories of Joshua and the people who served under him. The book of Joshua was probably close to its present form by the early years of Israel's monarchy, during the time of David and Solomon. The human author, or authors, of Joshua are not named.

Joshua as History

In the last two centuries, some scholars have questioned whether the book of Joshua gives a true history. They argue that Transjordan, the area east of the Jordan River, and the cities of Jericho and Ai were not occupied when Israel entered Canaan. If this were true, Israel could not have conquered them.

However, archaeological surveys show that Transjordan was occupied when Israel entered Canaan. Other archaeological evidence also supports the account of Jericho's destruction in Joshua.

Other scholars argue that stories written to explain something, such as the origin of a name, cannot also be true history. However, some ancient stories written for this purpose are false or legendary, while others are historically accurate. The content of Joshua was probably first written down near the time of the events it describes. The book gives many signs that it is historically accurate, even though it does not answer every historical question people may ask.

For most of the time that the book of Joshua has been part of Scripture, Christians and Jews have viewed it as reliable history. Joshua, Judges, Samuel, and Kings are different from the epic stories, myths, and royal praise texts of nearby cultures. These biblical books give a selective history of ancient Israel in the land where God placed them.

They were also written from a prophetic point of view. This means they explain Israel's history in light of Israel's covenant relationship with God. This is the same point of view found in Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the twelve Minor Prophets.

Joshua records only the main events of Israel's entry into Canaan. The book does not say or suggest that Israel destroyed all the Canaanites and their cities. Many Canaanites remained, as the book of Judges also makes clear. Judges tells the story of Israel over several generations. It shows that Israel slowly became stronger and the Canaanites became part of Israel. By the time of King David, most people in the land saw themselves as Israelites. However, some separate groups still remained (for example, [2 Samuel 5:6–8](#)).

Meaning and Message

The book of Joshua shows that God kept his covenant promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. A covenant is a binding agreement. The patriarchs, the early fathers of Israel, had traveled through the land as foreigners. Now their descendants lived in it because God had faithfully kept his promise. Even the burials at the end of the book show this truth. Abraham had to buy a small piece of land to bury Sarah. But the Israelites buried Joseph, Joshua, and Eleazar in the land God had given to their descendants.

The book of Joshua shows that God speaks and acts with complete honesty. We can trust him to keep his promises. The book teaches this truth in both clear and quiet ways. The two spies were faithful to Rahab and her family. Their faithfulness points to the faithfulness of God, who had brought them to Rahab's house. Caleb received his inheritance near the beginning of the land divisions. Joshua received his inheritance near the end. These two gifts show that God honors people who remain faithful to him throughout their lives.

Joshua also records that Israel built stone memorials throughout the land. These stone markers helped teach Israelite children about God's complete faithfulness. Later, these stones broke down or were taken away for other uses. But the book of Joshua still remains. It continues to testify to God's goodness and faithfulness.

The book of Joshua describes some troubling events. Israel destroyed Jericho and Ai and all their people. Many Israelites, including Achan and his family, died because of Achan's sin. God fought the Canaanite groups that tried to stop Israel from settling in the land. These and other events show the serious consequences of sin.

In a culture where women were often given little honor or protection, Joshua gives a different picture. When the land was divided among the clans of Manasseh, the daughters of Zelophehad received their father's inheritance, just as God had instructed. Rahab

also saved the two young spies in the dramatic opening part of the book. Her story shows that women have an honored place in God's work.

The book of Joshua gives people today much to consider about God. It shows the results of human good and evil. It also shows God's deep commitment to redeem people and restore their relationship with him.